MONTHLY UPDATE

Sierra Leone: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-3 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies · Legislation and regulation · Data protection

Strategies, plans and policies

DATA GOVERNANCE FRAMEWORK

- **Ministry of Communication strengthens partnership with UN on digital transformation** — Sierra Loaded, 5 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's communications minister Salima Bah met the UN Resident Coordinator, UNDP and UNFPA on data governance and digital infrastructure, reported on 5 September 2026, and showed them the Government Data Centre at NatCA Tower and plans for a backup site at State House. The ministry says it is drafting a Data Governance Framework on how government data is classified, shared and used.

OPEN SOURCE SOFTWARE POLICY

- **Sierra Leone to showcase open-source software policy at UNGA 81** — TechReviewAfrica, 15 September 2026

  The communications ministry will take its open-source software agenda to a side event at the United Nations General Assembly on 24 September, with a UN partner, arguing open source supports affordable, secure and locally owned digital systems.

- **UNGA81: Sierra Leone unveils Open Source Policy to address digital fragmentation and vendor lock-in** — Tech Review Africa, 25 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's communications ministry presented a new open source policy at a UNICEF event on the sidelines of UNGA81, as its answer to duplicated government systems, rising proprietary costs, systems that cannot interoperate and vendor lock-in. The policy's text, adoption date and instrument were not given.

Legislation and regulation

DIGITAL GOVERNMENT BILL

- **Government Reviews Security of Children s Vaccination Data** — Sierra Loaded, 11 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's communications and technology ministry, with UNICEF and the Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure, held a three-day workshop on safeguards for children's data in connected government systems, reported on 11 September 2026. Officials from 16 ministries worked on birth registration, vaccination records, education data and social protection, including who may access vaccination records and where breaches could occur.

Data protection

GUARDRAILS FOR CHILDREN'S DATA IN PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE

- **Sierra Leone enhances child data protection in connected government systems** — TechReviewAfrica, 10 September 2026

  Sierra Leone is strengthening safeguards for children's personal data as government institutions move toward more connected digital public infrastructure. The communication, technology and innovation ministry, with a United Nations children's agency and a digital public infrastructure centre, ran a three-day workshop on guardrails for children examining how government systems handle their data.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity · Energy · Cybersecurity

Connectivity

GOVERNMENT WIDE AND LOCAL AREA NETWORKS (GWAN AND GLANS)

- **Procurement Review Panel Probes Alleged Irregularities in Digital Transformation Project** — Truth Media Sierra Leone, 21 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's Independent Procurement Review Panel opened an investigation into alleged irregularities in the Digital Transformation Project's contract for government network systems (GWAN and GLANS), after a complaint by Tiwai Memory Masters Ltd against the communications ministry. The panel said the outcome will be published once the review is complete. No contract value is given.

- **IPRP Vindicates MoCTI** — Black News, 8 October 2026

  Sierra Leone's procurement review panel dismissed a bidder's complaint over the evaluation of the World Bank-funded government network contract. It directed the ministry to open financial proposals and proceed to award.

Energy

EMERGENT GRID COMPUTING PILOT AT RURAL MINI-GRIDS

- **The Rockefeller Foundation and Mission 300 Accelerator Launch Demonstration to Test Whether AI Demand Can Help Finance Energy Access in Africa** — The Rockefeller Foundation, 24 September 2026

  KENYA DRC AFRICA

  The Rockefeller Foundation's Mission 300 Accelerator announced the Emergent Grid Project on 24 September 2026, testing whether AI computing placed at African mini-grids can act as an anchor customer and improve their finances. The first sites are five in Kenya, a solar plant in DR Congo and three in Sierra Leone, serving about 85,000 people, with local electricity demand given priority over computing. No amount is stated.

Cybersecurity

ROAD SAFETY AUTHORITY VEHICLE LICENSING SYSTEM

- **SLRSA Alerts Public On Fake Vehicle Licences After Cyber Attack, 5 Arrested** — Sierra Leone Monitor, 5 October 2026

  The Sierra Leone Road Safety Authority said in a public notice dated 2 October 2026 that an intrusion into its IT systems was used to produce fake vehicle licences. Police arrested five people who are not SLRSA staff. The number of fake licences in circulation was not disclosed, and owners are asked to verify licences at SLRSA offices.

NATIONAL INTERNET DOMAIN REGISTRY COMPROMISE OF 25 SEPTEMBER 2026

- **Sierra Leone: Government confirms cyberattack on 44 websites** — This Day (Salone), 9 October 2026

  Sierra Leone's communications ministry confirmed that 44 website addresses, one a government institution's, were hit on 25 September through the system that administers the national internet domain. Service was restored the same day; how the attackers got in has not been made public.

DPI

Data Exchange · Digital Payments and Fintech · Registries · Sectoral management information systems · Other GovTech and e-Gov

Data Exchange

AFRICA ACCELERATOR FOR DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE (AA4DPI)

- **CDPI on its session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, 2–3 September 2026** — Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure (CDPI), 3 September 2026 ETHIOPIA MALAWI RWANDA ZAMBIA

  The Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure led a session at the Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, hosted by UNDP and the Centre for Open Societal Systems on 2 and 3 September 2026. Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia covered DPI blueprints, verifiable credentials, consented data sharing and reusable open-source code.

- **Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure (AA4DPI)** — United Nations Development Programme, 8 September 2026 AFRICA

  UNDP has published the standing description of its Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, led jointly by the Regional Bureau for Africa and the Digital and AI Hub, which supports countries to assess digital readiness, strengthen governance, build implementation capacity and develop investment-ready programmes across digital identity, digital payments and data exchange. Its first published cohort session ran on 2 and 3 September with delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia; no budget, duration or deliverable set is published for the accelerator itself.

- **UNDP's AA4DPI Programme Deepens South-South Cooperation on Digital Public Infrastructure** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), 8 September 2026 ETHIOPIA MALAWI RWANDA ZAMBIA AFRICA

  Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia, with African Union representatives, concluded a two-week South-South learning mission to India on digital public infrastructure. Convened under UNDP's newly launched Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, it took delegates through New Delhi, Pune and Bengaluru to examine India's digital identity, payment and data exchange systems.

ASYCUDA CUSTOMS SYSTEM

- **NRA Prepares to Launch Digital Customs System at Jendema Border** — Sierraloaded, 6 October 2026

  Sierra Leone's revenue authority has begun consultations with security agencies and local stakeholders at the Jendema border crossing as it prepares to launch the ASYCUDA World customs system there. The system will automate import, export and transit procedures; no launch date is given.

Digital Payments and Fintech

SMART GOODS AND SERVICES TAX MACHINES

- **NRA Begins Nationwide Distribution of Smart GST Machines to 10,000 Businesses** — The Calabash Newspaper, 2 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's National Revenue Authority began distributing Smart GST machines to 10,000 GST-registered businesses nationwide, announced on 31 August 2026. Commissioner-General Abu Martin Kanneh said the machines complement the existing electronic cash register system and will let businesses issue valid receipts. No cost or supplier is given.

PENSION AND SOCIAL SECURITY SELF-SERVICE APPLICATION

- **NASSIT Set to Launch New Mobile App for Pensioners** — Sierra Loaded, 7 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's social security trust is to launch a self-service application for pensioners and contributors, with a short-code fallback for feature phones, biometric verification and integration with the three mobile-money services. It is announced rather than launched, with no date published.

Registries

NATIONAL LAND TITLE CERTIFICATION

- **Land Title Certificate: A Blow To The Vulnerable?** — Apex News Sierra Leone, 14 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's lands minister, Turad Senesi, announced that Cabinet has approved a nationwide land title certificate system, which still needs parliamentary approval before it is implemented. The opinion piece asks how costs for registration and surveying will affect low-income and rural landholders and how customary land will be handled. No costs, procedures or timetable are given.

- **Sierra Leone: Govt. plans free nationwide land registration, minister says** — This Day Sierra Leone, 15 September 2026

  The lands minister said the government plans free nationwide land registration and title certification, with systematic registration of parcels across the country.

Sectoral management information systems

HEALTH DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE (DPI-H) ARCHITECTURE AND IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

- **NMSA MIS Manager Participates in Health Digital Infrastructure Workshop** — Sierraloaded, 19 September 2026

  Sierra Leone held a two-day workshop on 17 and 18 September 2026 on a shared digital public infrastructure for health, attended by the National Medical Supplies Agency among others. It mapped existing digital health systems, gaps and duplication, and discussed costing and funding. Participants planned a technical working group to validate the implementation plan. No decision is reported.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

SIERRASEAT AUDIT MANAGEMENT INFORMATION SYSTEM

- **Audit Service Sierra Leone Advances Digital Transformation with SierraSeat Post-Configuration Training** — AFROSAI-E, 3 September 2026

  Audit Service Sierra Leone trained 25 staff on SierraSeat, its audit management information system, from 3 to 5 August 2026, completing the final stage of user acceptance testing. The system is a localised version of AFROSAI-E's A-SEAT, funded by the World Bank. The service intends to declare it operational subject to testing and management approval.

VISION-SL MINISTERIAL PERFORMANCE PLATFORM

- **Chief Minister digitises Ministerial performance to strengthen accountability** — Concord Times, 12 October 2026

  Sierra Leone's Chief Minister, David Moinina Sengeh, opened a workshop at which ministries and agencies were shown VISION-SL, a digital platform to hold ministerial performance contracts, targets, indicators and quarterly progress reports in one system, reported on 12 October 2026. It is meant to track the national development plan and still awaits validation and testing. No cost or launch date is given.

Technology

AI · Innovation ecosystem

AI

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN THE 2028 ELECTIONS

- **ONS Warns AI Deepfakes Could Threaten Trust and Election Security Ahead of 2028** — Sierra Leone Monitor, 16 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's Office of National Security warned that AI-generated deepfakes and synthetic media threaten public trust and the security of the 2028 general elections. Its chief of staff, Francis Languba Keillie, called for systems to detect and respond to information threats, and for public institutions to set procedures for verifying suspicious content and protecting official accounts.

DEEPFAKE AND DIGITAL MISINFORMATION CAMPAIGN

- **Sierra Leone launches AI, deepfake campaign** — ITWeb Africa, 17 September 2026

  Sierra Leone launched a national artificial-intelligence and deepfake awareness campaign in Freetown, planned in two phases across all 16 districts. It is led by the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation with the communications and information ministries, and funded through the World Bank's digital transformation project.

NATIONAL AI ROADMAP FOR THE JUSTICE SECTOR

- **Sierra Leone to develop national AI roadmap for justice sector with UNESCO support** — Tech Review Africa, 5 October 2026

  Sierra Leone's judiciary and the attorney-general's office are to draft a national artificial-intelligence roadmap for the justice sector with UNESCO, beginning with the security sector. Participants at the convening pointed to electronic filing and digital case management; no timetable is given.

Innovation ecosystem

STARTUP ACT

- **First Lady Fatima Bio Leads Official Launch of 'Flot' Digital Financial Platform** — Sierraloaded, 12 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's First Lady Fatima Bio launched Flot, a fintech platform built with Zenith Bank Sierra Leone and Visa, in Freetown on 12 September 2026; it offers a Visa card for international payments. Communications Minister Salima Mormorna Bah said the government plans a Startup Act, expected in the first quarter of 2027, and an Innovation Investment Fund.

DIGITAL PUBLIC GOODS PIPELINE

- **UNGA81: Four Sierra Leonean teams submit Digital Public Goods to Global Registry** — Tech Review Africa, 25 September 2026

Four Sierra Leonean teams met all nine Digital Public Goods criteria and submitted their products to the global registry, it was announced at a UNICEF event at UNGA81, with three more teams meeting six or seven criteria. The Christex Foundation, which prepared them over six to seven months, used its own AI-assisted assessment tool, Pipeline.

- **UNGA81: Sierra Leone unveils Open Source Policy to address digital fragmentation and vendor lock-in** — Tech Review Africa, 25 September 2026

  Summarised under Strategies, plans and policies.

Capacity

Literacy · Training and skills · Research institutions

Literacy

NATIONAL AI AND DEEPFAKE SENSITIZATION CAMPAIGN

- **Information Minister Launches National AI, Deepfake Sensitization Campaign** — The Nationalist, 17 September 2026

  Sierra Leone launched a national AI and deepfake awareness campaign at a stakeholder meeting organised with the ministries of information and of communication, technology and innovation. Information minister Bah said the government is building info.gov.sl, a site for verifying official content by QR code, and is developing a national AI policy.

Training and skills

CIVIL SERVICE DIGITAL SKILLS PROGRAMME

- **Sierra Leone expands digital skills training for civil servants** — TechReviewAfrica, 20 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's Ministry of Communication, Technology and Innovation is training civil servants in digital skills with the public administration ministry, the Human Resource Management Office and the Public Service Academy. In its second week, reported on 20 September 2026, the first cohort of administrative staff learned to draft letters and reports with AI tools and keep registers in Google Workspace; the cohort ends on 25 September.

Research institutions

CIPHER INFORMATION PRIVACY RESEARCH CENTRE

- **CIPHER Launched to Promote Data Protection, Cybersecurity and Digital Privacy** — Truth Media, 9 October 2026

  The Center for Information Privacy, Human-Centered Technology and Ethics Research (CIPHER), an independent research body, launched in Freetown, Sierra Leone, on 6 October 2026. Its chief executive, Cyril Foday-Kallie, said it will research mishandling of personal data, train people on data-subject rights and controllers' duties, and supply evidence for data-protection law and policy.

Inclusion

Access to services

Access to services

DPI INCLUSIVITY SURVEY

- **Global Development Network kicks off deployment of its five-country DPI Inclusivity Survey** — Global Development Network — Inclusive Digital Transformation Hub, 7 September 2026 GHANA GLOBAL

  The Global Development Network has begun fieldwork on a five-country DPI Inclusivity Survey covering Sierra Leone and Ghana alongside Chile, Bangladesh and Indonesia, with partner teams at the Institute for Development and the University of Ghana. Running to April and engaging more than 5,000 households, it asks whether digital identity and digital payment systems leave people feeling more economically, socially and politically included, rather than measuring registration and access.

IDENTITY REGISTRATION OF PERSONS IN CORRECTIONAL CUSTODY

- **NCRA Marks International Identity Day with Registration Drive for 100 Inmates** — The Calabash Newspaper, 18 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's National Civil Registration Authority registered 100 inmates from three Freetown correctional centres for National Identification Numbers on 17 September 2026, International Identity Day. The inmates will receive ID cards free, with the government meeting the cost. The Correctional Service said the exercise builds on inmate biometric registration pilots in 2018 and 2020.

Data

National statistics

National statistics

2025 VITAL STATISTICS REPORT

- **NCRA Begins Validation of Sierra Leone's 2025 Vital Statistics Report** — Sierra Loaded, 11 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's National Civil Registration Authority held a two-day meeting on 10 and 11 September 2026 to validate the draft 2025 Vital Statistics Report, focusing on fertility and mortality data. Director General Mohamed Mubashir Massaquoi called for greater national ownership of civil registration data and said figures from multiple external sources produce inconsistencies.

2026 POPULATION AND HOUSING CENSUS

- **Sierra Leone's President Bio Calls For Faster Development Delivery, Stronger Coordination At DEPAC Meeting** — Office of the President of Sierra Leone, 11 September 2026

  Sierra Leone's President Julius Maada Bio told the Presidential Development Partners Committee in Freetown on 10 September 2026 that the 2026 Population and Housing Census faces a US$37 million financing gap. Government has committed US$24 million, about US$15 million of it disbursed, and partners about US$1.5 million; Census Night is set for 1 December 2026.

- **Stats SL Completes Nationwide Mapping Ahead of December Census** — Sierraloaded, 18 September 2026

  Statistics Sierra Leone completed nationwide mapping for the December 2026 census, the country's first digital census, and the census technical committee received the mapping completion report on 15 September. The committee also reviewed an August mock census; Census Night is set for 1 December.

- **Stats SL Completes Mapping, Deploys Digital Systems Ahead of 2026 Census** — SierraLoaded, 7 October 2026

Statistics Sierra Leone announced on 7 October 2026 that it has deployed the technology for the December census, including 500 tablets for mapping, ArcGIS Pro and satellite imagery. It said the government has spent more than US$20 million on census preparations. Enumerators will collect data on tablets from 2 to 16 December 2026.

- **2026 Census Budget Rises From $7 Million to Nearly $60 Million – Stats SL Boss Andrew Johnny** — SierraLoaded, 12 October 2026

  The budget for Sierra Leone's 2026 Population and Housing Census has risen from an initial US$7 million to nearly US$60 million, Statistics Sierra Leone's Andrew Bob Johnny said at the 50-day countdown event in Freetown. The estimate was revised after nationwide mapping and covers enumeration through dissemination; funding is expected from government, donors and the private sector.

- **Sierra Leone counts down to first fully digital census** — The Sierra Leone Telegraph, 13 October 2026

  Sierra Leone opened the 50-day countdown to its 2026 Population and Housing Census, its first fully digital enumeration. Census Night is 1 December and nationwide enumeration starts the next day.

Geopolitics

India activities

India activities

INDIA DIGITAL PUBLIC INFRASTRUCTURE LEARNING MISSION

- **Karnataka Hosts African Union, Five African Nations For Digital Public Infrastructure Exposure Visit** — The Bengaluru Live, 1 September 2026 ETHIOPIA MALAWI RWANDA ZAMBIA

  The Indian state of Karnataka hosted officials from the African Union, Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on 1 September 2026, on a UNDP-supported visit to study digital public infrastructure. State officials and the Centre for e-Governance briefed the delegation on digitising public services and interoperability between government systems.

- **African Delegations Explore India's Digital Public Infrastructure During UNDP Learning Mission** — Youth Village Zambia, 2 September 2026 ZAMBIA ETHIOPIA MALAWI RWANDA

  The UN Development Programme in India hosted delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia on a learning mission on digital public infrastructure in New Delhi, Pune and Bangalore in early September 2026. The visits covered Aadhaar digital identity, the Unified Payments Interface and DigiLocker, with meetings at India's identity authority, its national payments corporation and the health and agriculture ministries.

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